educo

www.educo.org educoBangladesh educo-bangladesh +880 2 41 080 858- 59

KOICA Korea International Cooperation Agency

ChorogUsan for children

educo

SMALL HANDS, NEW DREAMS

Credit Line

Coordinated by

Afzal Kabir Khan, Manager–Child Labour Elimination, Educo Bangladesh

Mohammad Mijanur Rahman, Project Officer–Child Labour Elimination, Educo Bangladesh

Md. Kamal Hossain, Project Coordinator, ESDO

Editor

Noore Tamanna, Assistant Officer-Documentation & Reporting, Educo Bangladesh

Sadia Karim, Manager–Communication, Educo Bangladesh

Tahmina Akter, Communication Officer, Educo Bangladesh

Special thanks to the project team of

Eco-Social Development Organization-ESDO

Education and Development Foundation-EDUCO

Photo courtesy

Zanala Bangladesh

Tahmina Akter, Communication Officer, Educo Bangladesh

Funded by

ChorogUsan for Children and Educo Bangladesh

Published by

Educo Bangladesh

Published year

2025

Table of Content

1. **Growing Through Adversity: The Journey of Sajib** 04
2. **Jannatul Became a Torch Bearer for Other Girls in Her Community** 08
3. **From Shoe Factory to Classroom: How Education Transformed Abdullah's Life** 12
4. **Lima's Journey from Fear to Hope** 16
5. **Turning Struggles into Strength** 20
6. **From Shadows of Hardship to Dreams of Justice** 24
7. **Education Becomes the Only Escape from Life's Cruelty** 28
8. **Fixing Dreams, Not Just Machines: Hasan's Story of Resilience** 32

Project Overview

In the dense slum communities of Dhaka city, thousands of children are engaged in labour, often at the cost of their right to education. To address this challenge, the project "**Strengthening the Right to Education for Child Labourers in Dhaka City**" has been jointly implemented by ChorogUsan for Children (CUFC), Educo Bangladesh, and the Eco Social Development Organization (ESDO), with financial support from the Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA).

Implemented from December 2022 to December 2025, the project seeks to ensure that working children living in urban slums can access and enjoy their basic right to education. Recognizing the complex realities faced by child labourers, the project focuses on creating inclusive and child-friendly learning environments that respond to their specific needs, work conditions, and life experiences.

Beyond education, the initiative works to build community awareness, strengthen parental and stakeholder engagement, and promote institutional accountability to safeguard the educational rights of child labourers. The project directly supports 800 child labourers and their parents, while indirectly reaching around 250,000 community members through awareness and advocacy efforts.

Project interventions are concentrated in key child labour sectors such as domestic work, transport services, automobile workshops, waste scavenging, leather and footwear production, and plastic recycling. Activities are implemented across eight communities in six thanas of Dhaka North and South City Corporations, including Darus Salam, Adabor, Mohammadpur, Hazaribagh, Lalbagh, and Kamrangirchar.

Acknowledgement

The case story book has been developed with the collective efforts, commitment, and cooperation of many individuals. This publication reflects not only documented outcomes, but also the shared commitment to ensuring that working children are protected from hazardous labour and supported to live with dignity, hope, and opportunity.

My heartfelt gratitude goes to the children, young people, and their families whose real-life journeys are at the heart of this booklet. Their courage, resilience, and determination to move away from hazardous work and pursue safer, more dignified lives are truly inspiring. I also acknowledge the valuable contributions of community members and local stakeholders who stood beside these children and supported positive change at the grassroots level.

I sincerely recognize the dedication of the project team, field staff, and partner organizations for their tireless efforts in implementation, follow-up, documentation, and review. Their professionalism and commitment ensured that these stories were captured with care, accuracy, and respect. Special appreciation is extended to the management and technical teams for their strategic guidance and continuous encouragement throughout the development of this publication.

This case story booklet has been developed under the project "**Strengthening the Right to Education for Child Labourers in Dhaka City**," jointly implemented by ChorogUsan for Children (CUFC), Educo Bangladesh, and the Eco Social Development Organization, with the generous financial support of the Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA). Implemented from December 2022 to December 2025, the project has played a vital role in improving access to education and safeguarding the rights of child labourers living in the slum areas of Dhaka.

Finally, I gratefully acknowledge our donors and partners for their trust, collaboration, and continued support. It is our sincere hope that this case story booklet will serve as a learning resource, inspire stakeholders, and strengthen collective efforts toward eliminating hazardous child labour and ensuring a dignified future for every child.

Abdul Hamid
Country Director
Education and Development Foundation-Educo

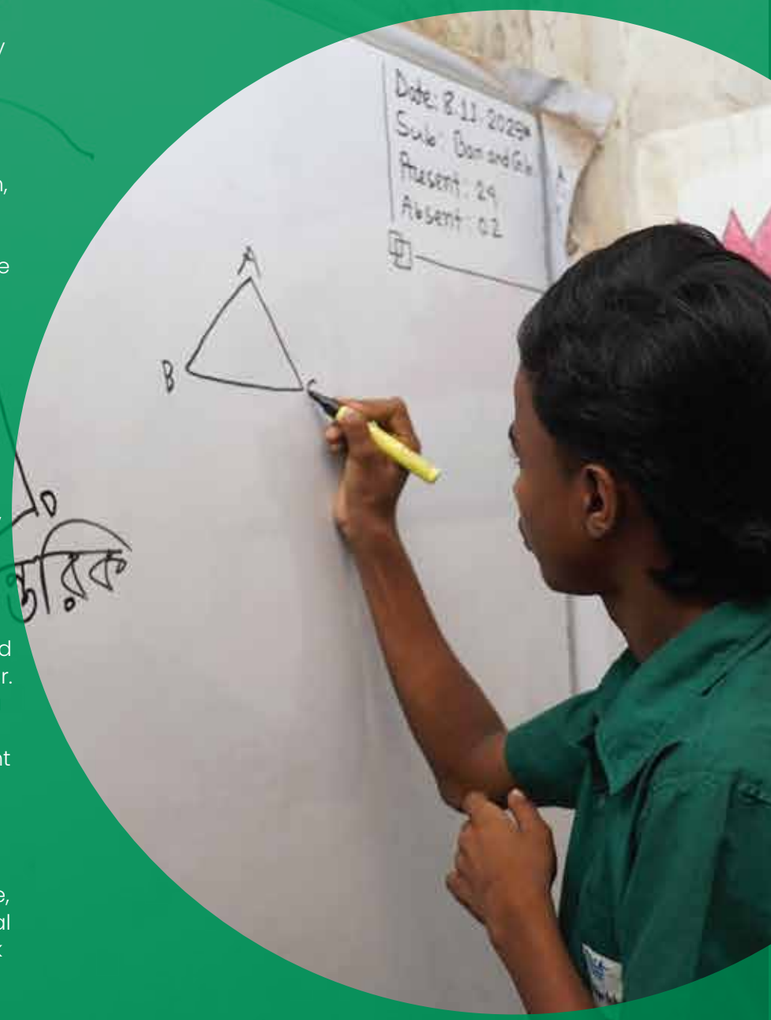
Growing Through Adversity: **The Journey of Sajib**

> I want to study hard and learn computer work so I can earn with dignity. One day, I will help my mother and others who struggle like we did.

Bridge School is an initiative under the "Strengthening Education Right for Child Labourer in Dhaka" project, funded by the Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA), a government agency of South Korea, technically supported by Educo Bangladesh and co-implemented by ESDO. The project helps child labourers in Dhaka city to study by providing cost-free education, tiffin, and educational materials. Additionally, teachers and Community Led Child Labour Monitoring Committee (CLCLMC) members from the community advocate for a child-labour-free society by making parents, employers, and others aware of the consequences of child labour.

Sajib's family originally came from Bhola, where severe river erosion washed away their land and livelihood, forcing them to relocate. Seeking a fresh start, his parents migrated to Dhaka and settled in an informal settlement. His father worked as a rickshaw puller, while his mother earned a modest income as a domestic helper. During this time, Sajib was enrolled in a local madrasa. Life was difficult but manageable until an unexpected event changed everything. Sajib's father remarried and abandoned the family, plunging them into deep distress.

Overwhelmed and struggling to survive, his mother continued working in several households while his elder brother took a job as a helper on a leguna. Even then, the combined cost of daily living and educational expenses became too heavy to manage. When Sajib was 11, he had to discontinue his studies and



begin working in a local garage. The environment was harsh and he was frequently scolded and overburdened with work. One day, unable to bear the mistreatment any longer, he broke down and told his mother that he no longer wanted to work. That moment marked a turning point in his life.

Around this time, Sajib's mother learned about the Bridge School, where working children can continue their education without financial burden, studying for half the day and working the other half. Recognising the opportunity, she contacted one of the teachers, and Sajib was soon admitted into Class 3. He began attending regularly while still doing part-time work.

Sajib's mother became actively engaged in parent meetings, where teachers emphasised the importance of education for working children and encouraged families to support their transition away from labour. With their guidance and her own determination, she eventually made the crucial decision to withdraw Sajib from work completely so that he could focus on his education full time.

Since joining the Bridge School, Sajib has flourished into a confident and motivated learner. He has developed a strong interest in computers and has already acquired basic digital skills through the school's facilities. His academic performance has improved significantly, and he now imagines a future built on dignity and opportunity.

Sajib dreams of becoming a freelance professional. He wants to continue his studies, earn an income through online work, and support his mother and brother. Just as

importantly, he hopes to help other children facing challenges similar to those he once endured. He shared, "I want to study hard and learn computer work so I can earn with dignity. One day, I will help my mother and others who struggle like we did."

Sajib's journey, from a child labourer in a hostile work environment to an ambitious young student, demonstrates the transformative power of education and the hope it brings to children navigating hardship and uncertainty.

Jannatul
Became a Torch Bearer for Other Girls in Her Community

> My daughter always loved learning, but our financial condition held her back. Finally, when she joined the Bridge School and started thriving, my heart felt at ease. Now, I believe she has a great future ahead.

At just 13, Jannatul Ferdous is doing something that takes a lifetime for many to do, becoming a light for others by pulling herself out of darkness.

Born in a village in Netrokona, life never treated her softly. At an early age, she lost her father, the sole breadwinner of the family. With no other option for survival, her mother, leaving everything behind, brought the whole family to the capital for better livelihood opportunities.

Life in the capital wasn't great as well. Her mother took jobs as a domestic helper. To support her, Jannatul and her two younger brothers also started working. She, like her mother, started to work as a household helper. Her income helps her mother pay the rent and buy some food for the family.

She is a bright and curious child who, deep inside, was seeking opportunities to return to school. However, financial constraints and workloads made education seem impossible to her. One day, when she discovered the

Bridge School, which made education possible and totally free for working children like her, Jannatul discussed it with her mother and her employer. Initially, they were hesitant, but seeing her eagerness for education, her employer agreed on the condition that Jannatul had to complete her work responsibly besides her school.

Determined, Jannatul at first began managing both work and school, working early mornings and late evenings while attending school during the day. This commitment was reflected in her strong presence in school activities. Over time, her academic performance and confidence grew. Her relentless eagerness and hard work for her studies

> I want to become a doctor and serve poor families who cannot afford treatment.

moved everyone's heart, and today, Jannatul no longer works.

Now she is a student of class 5 in Hazaribagh Bridge School. Her mother said, "My daughter always loved learning, but our financial condition held her back. Finally, when she joined the Bridge School and started thriving, my heart felt at ease. Now, I believe she has a great future ahead."

In school, Jannatul is also famous for helping her classmates who struggle to understand lessons. Through this, she not only showed her leadership qualities but also a cooperative mindset towards her peers. She also teaches children in her community;

some of them also pay her. She now earns around BDT 2,000 a month; with this amount, she helps her mother. Her kind and cooperative mindset made her a role model for other learners in her school as well as in her community. Jannatul dreams of becoming a doctor one day. She expressed, "I want to become a doctor and serve poor families who cannot afford treatment."

Jannatul's story is a powerful example of how the right support, along with personal determination and hard work, can transform the lives of children who are otherwise left behind due to poverty.

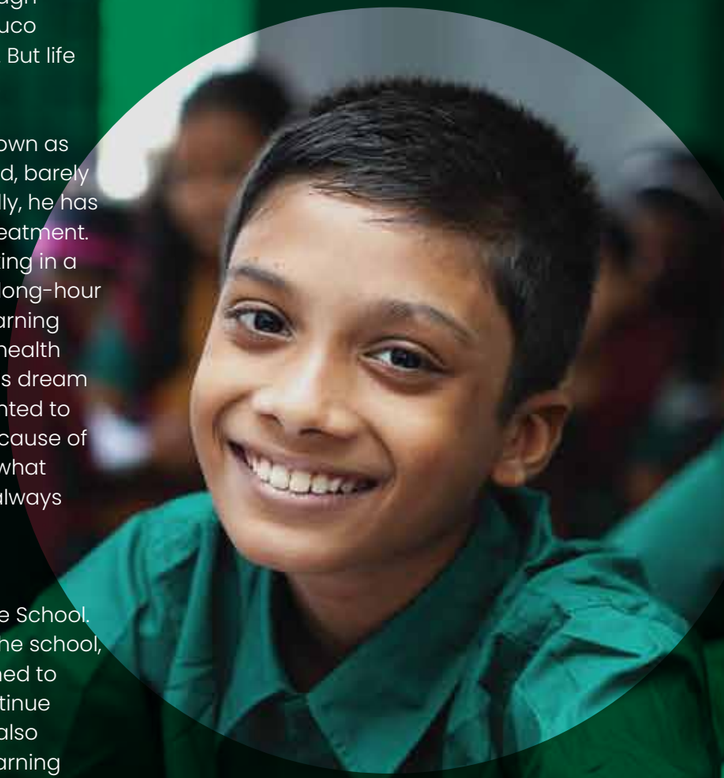
> I wanted to continue studying, but it wasn't possible because of our financial situation. If I didn't go to work, what would we eat? That was the question that always spun around my mind.

From Shoe Factory to Classroom: **How Education Transformed Abdullah's Life**

Md. Abdullah, 11, is a bright student currently studying in Class 5 under the KOICA-funded Hazaribagh Bridge School initiative, implemented by Educo Bangladesh and co-implemented by ESDO. But life was very different before he started school.

His father works as a mosque caretaker, known as khadem in Bengali. His income is very limited, barely enough to feed the family of five. Additionally, he has a respiratory disease that requires costly treatment. To support the family, Abdullah began working in a shoe factory for very minimal income, with long-hour shifts. Despite having a strong interest in learning since childhood, poverty and his father's ill health made it impossible to attend school, and his dream of studying began to fade. He shared, "I wanted to continue studying, but it wasn't possible because of our financial situation. If I didn't go to work, what would we eat? That was the question that always spun around my mind."

However, things took a positive turn when neighbours informed them about the Bridge School. With Abdullah and his parents also visited the school, they discovered that the school was designed to help children like him, allowing them to continue education without financial pressure. They also discovered that the school provides free learning materials such as books, notepads, school bags, nutritious tiffin, and a child-friendly environment for cognitive and emotional development.



Abdullah was soon enrolled in Class 3 and began attending classes regularly. The teachers' caring approach and psychosocial support system helped him regain his confidence. The CLCLMC committee and school teachers even visited his workplace to raise awareness among his employer about the consequences of child labour. Hearing the facts, Abdullah's employer became flexible. For the first time, Abdullah could study without worrying about his workload.

He quickly became a regular, enthusiastic learner who performs well in all subjects. His teachers appreciate his polite behaviour, punctuality, and eagerness to help others. One of his teachers said, "Abdullah is one of the most well-behaved and disciplined students in the school. He is friendly, punctual, and cooperative with others."

Gradually, his father's health improved and the family's situation has stabilised. His father now supplements his income by teaching Arabic lessons, and Abdullah no longer has to work in the shoe factory. This has allowed him to focus entirely on his studies.

Abdullah now dreams of becoming a teacher, inspired by the guidance and care of his own educators at the Bridge School. He expressed, "Now, I study full time and dreams of becoming a teacher and educate children like me."

Abdullah's transformation from a child labourer to a motivated learner is a clear testament to the impact of the Educo's efforts. His story reflects the broader mission of the project: empowering children through education, breaking the cycle of poverty, and helping them build a future filled with hope and opportunity.

Lima's Journey from Fear to Hope

> I didn't like staying at my house because of my father, I was always stay alert so that I wouldn't make him angry.

Have you ever imagined how life would be if you had an abusive father, creating an environment of fear and distress from your earliest years? This was the reality for Lima while growing up and she is only 13 now.

Lamiya Akter, affectionately called Lima, is a student in class 5 at Mohammadpur Bridge School. She was born in Dhaka, where her parents moved to Dhaka in search of a better life. Unfortunately, life was not peaceful. Her father was an unemployed man and habitually mistreated her mother. From an early age, Lima has been witnessing this environment of fear and distress. She shared, "I didn't like staying at my house because of my father, I was always stay alert so that I wouldn't make him angry."

Lima attended an NGO school near her residence but could not continue due to the instability within her family. After a while, her father left them for good, and her mother became seriously ill. With her mother's health deteriorating, Lima had no choice but to start working. At just 11 years old, Lima started working as a domestic helper to support her household for BDT 1500 a month. The combination of poverty, trauma, and the absence of parental support left her future uncertain and heart heavy.

Life began to change in 2023 when she first heard about the Bridge School initiative. Encouraged by her mother, she was admitted into class 3 and soon after she began to excel in

her exams. Lima shared her experience from the first day of school, “At first, I was scared but the teachers’ friendliness made me feel at ease. My classmates were also very kind to me. I felt very happy when I receive new books, pens and a school bag.” The school’s flexible timing for working children was especially helpful. Seeing her keen interest in learning and good results, her employers became gentle towards her.

At the beginning of 2025, Lima completely stop working, as her mother’s health improved, she now holds the grip of the family. Lima is performing exceptionally well in Bangla, English, and Mathematics and consistently achieving the highest marks in examinations. Beyond education, the Bridge School has also provided her with psychosocial counselling, helping her overcame the fear of people and develop a positive outlook on life.

Lima’s education has brought renewed purpose and stability to their small family. She shared, “After joining Bridge School, I started dreaming again. Now, I want to study hard and become a teacher one day.” She added, “I want to work for children like me, those who had to work but dream of learning. My biggest wish is to ease my mother’s pain and make her proud.”

With Educo Bangladesh’s support, Lima’s life has taken a new direction. From a child labourer struggling with fear and hardship, she has grown into a confident student with dreams of becoming a teacher. Her journey reflects the impact of Educo’s commitment to inclusive and equitable education for all children, especially those from vulnerable and marginalised communities.

Turning **Struggles into Strength**

> If Bridge School didn’t exist, my dream of going to school would have remained just a dream. Here, I can study, play, and learn even while working.

Coming from a family of interreligious marriage, Md Ratul Biswas, 13 years old, was already in a disadvantaged position in society, the suffering of social rejection compounded by the river erosion which made them homeless. After losing everything to the disaster, they moved to the Lalbagh area of Dhaka, hoping to rebuild their lives from nothing.

Dhaka brought its own struggles. His father began pulling a rickshaw van, and his mother found work as a domestic helper. Ratul and his sister were enrolled in school. Life was better for a while. Suddenly, his mother fell ill and had to stop working. This made the family financially vulnerable again. In 2019, Ratul and his sister were forced to drop out and join a plastic factory, earning a meagre BDT 600 per week. The situation got worse following their father's sudden disappearance, which pushed the family deeper into crisis. During the COVID-19 lockdown, they often went to sleep hungry, unsure of when they would next eat. This situation placed Ratul to shoulder responsibilities far beyond his years.

Yet throughout these challenges, Ratul's desire to study never faded. In 2023, he was introduced to the Bridge School and requested his mother for a chance to return to learning. She agreed, balancing his school hours with part-time factory work. From the moment he entered Class 2, Ratul thrived. Teachers immediately noticed his determination and talent. He excelled in his studies and loved taking part in drawing, singing, dancing, and computer classes. He is in Class 5 now. Ratul shared, "If Bridge School didn't exist, my dream of going to school would have remained just a dream. Here, I can study, play, and learn even while working."

Today, Ratul continues to work part-time to support his family, earning around BDT 800 a week. His mother works tirelessly despite being physically weak, and his sister now supports the family through jewellery-making work. Bridge School provides Ratul with all his educational materials, easing the financial strain.

Now, Ratul holds onto hope. Dreaming of becoming a renowned artist one day, he remains grateful for the support he has received and expressed, "I hope Educo and ESDO will continue helping children like us to chase our dreams."

From Shadows of Hardship to **Dreams of Justice**

> My daughter is such a polite girl; she rarely complains though life has been very hard on her. I want her to study and grow strong.

Tamanna Akhter, 13, carries the weight of a childhood interrupted too soon. Born in Bhola, her life changed forever when her father, a hardworking truck driver, suddenly died in a devastating accident. She had just turned 2 then. Left with her mother, Tamanna's earliest years were steeped in struggle, living in cramped and fragile shelters, battling illness, and facing the bitter sting of loss.

They moved to Dhaka, where her mother started working as a domestic worker and took her children with her wherever she worked. At first, Tamanna began school near her residence, but the pull of poverty took education away, forcing her into labour to help them survive. So, the dream of a childhood filled with learning and laughter seemed out of reach. She worked as a domestic worker for BDT 2,000 a month.

Then, hope quietly arrived. Bridge School teachers came knocking, bringing a new promise to Tamanna's door. They spoke to her mother with compassion and conviction, lighting a spark that reignited Tamanna's education. Slowly, she returned to the classroom, joining Bridge School in fifth grade. She was juggling studies with hardship but never giving up.

Despite the hardships of a home surrounded by mosquitoes and filled with sickness, Tamanna found refuge within the school's four walls. She found school filled with warm teachers, joyful learning, and the chance to dream again. Her smile masks the quiet strength of a girl who has known too much pain but refuses to be defined by it. Her mother said, "My daughter is such a polite girl; she rarely complains though life has been very hard on her. I want her to study and grow strong."

Teachers marvel at her dedication and cultural talents such as dancing, singing, and drawing, finding strength and joy in every lesson she learns. The school community has witnessed a remarkable transformation in her behaviour, which now shines as brightly as her grades. Recognising her potential, the CLCLMC and school teachers persuaded her mother to withdraw her from work so that she could dedicate herself fully to her education.

Understanding the importance of learning and the harmful effects of child labour, her mother agreed to work harder so that her daughter could build a brighter future. She dreams as only a child can, with innocence and determination. "When I grow up, I want to be a police officer. I will protect the helpless and fight for justice. I want to make a difference in this world," she said with conviction.

Today, Tamanna no longer carries the burden of work on her small shoulders. Supported by Educo Bangladesh, KOICA, and ESDO, she walks confidently toward a future where hope, dignity, and justice shine brightly.

Education Becomes the Only Escape from **Life's Cruelty**

"Will you admit me too? I really want to study. Sometimes I feel very sad," he said quietly. "I wish I could just study and play like other children.

In the narrow lanes of Lalbagh, Dhaka, 12-year-old Ibrahim Khalilullah dreams of a life beyond hardship. Born in Madaripur district, he has seen more cruelty than most adults could bear. The youngest of five siblings, Ibrahim grew up in a home filled not with laughter but with the sounds of violence and despair.

His father, once a capable man, became addicted to gambling and drugs and also began to abuse his wife and children. When the abuse became unbearable, his mother finally fled to Dhaka with her children, desperate to rebuild their lives.

Here, his mother began working as a domestic helper while his older siblings found jobs in shoe, garment, and tile factories. For a while, life seemed to improve. But hardship soon returned. One sister disappeared, and his elder brother suffered an injury that stopped him from working. Their father reappeared and took the youngest sister with him. His mother moved elsewhere for work, leaving 8-year-old Ibrahim in the care of his brother.

But life took another difficult turn when his brother married. His sister-in-law refused to support him, insisting that Ibrahim start working to contribute to the household. Pressured and helpless, his brother sent him to work in a shoe factory for only BDT 2,000 a month for long hours. Despite his exhaustion, he never let go of his dream to study. Over time, his pay rose to BDT 3,500, but the longing for education only grew stronger.

One afternoon, while carrying a pile of shoes, Ibrahim noticed a group of teachers visiting the area. They were from the Bridge School, an initiative of Educo Bangladesh, funded by ChildFund Korea and co-implemented by ESDO. Gathering his courage, he approached them and said softly, "Will you admit me too? I really want to study."

The teachers were moved. They visited his home and spoke to his brother and sister-in-law, but both refused as they depended on Ibrahim's income. Refusing to give up, the teachers and the Community Led Child Labour Monitoring Committee (CLCLMC) met with his employer, who kindly agreed to let Ibrahim attend school part-time.

In 2023, Ibrahim finally joined the Bridge School. Now a student of Class 5, he thrives in an environment filled with learning, creativity, and hope. He enjoys drawing, computer lessons, and sports, experiences that once seemed out of reach.

> "I really love using the computer at school. One day, I'll be a computer engineer.

"Sometimes I feel very sad," he said quietly. "I wish I could just study and play like other children."

The school also provides psychosocial counselling and nutritious meals, often the only proper food Ibrahim gets in a day. Through regular counselling with his family and employer, attitudes have begun to change. Today, he works part-time in a safer job at a whiteboard company and continues his studies.

Ibrahim's journey is one of resilience and hope. His eyes light up when he speaks of his future, expressing, "I really love using the computer at school. One day, I'll be a computer engineer."

His story is a testament to the transformative power of education, proof that even in the darkest corners of hardship, learning can ignite the light of possibility.

Fixing Dreams, Not Just Machines: **Hasan's Story of Resilience**

> One day, I will be an automobile engineer, and I will build cars, not just fix broken ones. I want to prove that boys like me can achieve great things.

Mohammad Hasan, 13, spends his days balancing two different worlds, one working in a garage fixing machines and the other sitting in a classroom with his schoolbooks. His hands, often scraped and sore from turning wrenches, still hold tightly to the dream of becoming an automobile engineer one day.

His father pulls a rickshaw, and his mother works as a domestic helper. Though both work hard, their combined income could not support schooling for their children. To support the family, Hasan, the eldest child of the family, works at a local garage, earning just BDT 500 a month.

> I was terrified. All I could think was, what if I could never write again?”

The garage is no place for a child. He moves heavy tools, handles dangerous machines, and endures long hours. One accident nearly changed his life forever when a spinning machine caught his clothing; a split-second intervention by his employer saved his hand. He vividly remembered the event and shared, “I was terrified. All I could think was, what if I could never write again?”

Despite these challenges, Hasan’s commitment to learning never faded. His yearning for learning found an opportunity when the teachers from the Bridge School, an initiative by Educo Bangladesh funded by KOICA for strengthening the rights of children, convinced Hasan’s parents to send him to school. With help from the school, he was able to enroll in Class 3 and resume his education. The school offers him not just free learning but also a safe space where teachers provide emotional support and regularly follow up on his wellbeing.

Now a regular student of Class 5, Hasan studies during the day and works part-time in the evenings. His teachers describe him as responsible, humble, and intelligent. He is a student with strong potential to excel if given the right support. Hasan said with a smile, “Studying makes me feel like I am moving forward.”

After learning the importance of education from the teachers and CLCLMC members, Hasan’s mother continues to encourage his education. Even his employer, having seen his dedication, raises his wages to BDT 1,300 and ensures that he receives his wages on time so that he can stay in school while supporting the family.

His story is a powerful reflection of how poverty and inherited debt push children into unsafe labour, but also how education, community support, and personal resilience can offer a path out. Hasan expressed with quiet determination, “One day, I will be an automobile engineer, and I will build cars, not just fix broken ones. I want to prove that boys like me can achieve great things.”